

DIVINE POWER AND EVIL SPIRITS

magic and medieval Christianity



▲ Devil's advocate

Zoroaster (also called Zarathustra) was an ancient Persian spiritual leader described by Roman author Pliny the Elder as the inventor of magic. The Christian church took a dim view of such an accolade. In this miniature from 1425 he is depicted with two demons.

As churchmen worked to establish the influence of Christianity in the medieval period, they tried to show the superiority of divine power to that of evil spirits. Clergy sometimes recognized people's yearning for supernatural help, and offered them saints, miracles, and prayers in place of shamans, magic, and spells. Saints, in particular, were placed in counterpoint to magicians as guardians and protectors of humanity.

Devilish practice

Magic was mostly viewed as a threat to Christianity. The clergy saw it as evil, and they tried to stamp it out. Practitioners of magic began to be demonized as purveyors of *sortilegium* (sorcery) or *maleficium* (evil practice). Those accused were often the poor and vulnerable, and they were said to distort Christian rites to do the Devil's work.

Charlemagne's General Admonition of 789 CE required magicians and enchanters to repent or face death. But clearly it was not very effective: in 829 the Council of Paris described the existence of conjurors who could play tricks on the mind, and *malefici* (evil-doers) who could call down storms and hail and predict the future. Ironically, much of what is now known about early medieval magic comes from the writings of those Church scholars who tried to define this threat, such as the 6th-century *Etymology* by Isidore of Seville.

The power of relics

As time went on, people began to believe that Christian symbols had their own apotropaic powers (able to avert evil influences or bad luck). People started wearing Christian images such as crosses to ward off evils, particularly sickness and poverty, just as they had previously relied on amulets with pagan symbols.

The cult of relics offered yet more protection. In the 11th and 12th centuries, pilgrims went out of their way to visit a holy relic, whether a saint's finger, a fragment of the True Cross, or cloth worn

SAINT AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO (353–430 CE)

Condemning magic

Augustine lived in Hippo Regius in what is now Algeria, and was one of the early Christian church's most influential thinkers. Not everyone agreed with his ideas, which he expressed in such books as *City of God*, but they dominated Christian views for over a thousand years. Augustine was determined to separate Christianity from paganism so he took a hard line on magic, which he argued was taught by the Devil and acted out by demons. To perform magic, he declared, was to make a pact with the Devil—an assertion which, much later, was used to condemn witches.

